

appeared astounded. I thereupon suggested a recess—a suggestion the labor side seized upon gratefully. We adjourned the meeting, agreeing to resume it in the late afternoon.

My assistants were glum. They were certain I had taken the first steps toward giving away not only my company, but my shirt and theirs as well. They were convinced I'd handed the union the proverbial inch—and that it would consequently insist on taking its mile. At best, they

111

expected the union to double its demands; at worst, they feared a long, costly strike.

When the meeting resumed, my aides filed into the conference room with the air of men being led to the tumbrels.

I said nothing, but grinned inwardly at their discomfiture. I still believed I had assessed the situation correctly and had followed the right course, a belief soon verified by the union spokesman's opening remarks.

"To tell you the truth, we thought we were in for a long, tough fight," he declared. "But you laid everything on the line and gave us all the facts at the beginning—so there's really nothing to argue about." He paused and reached across the table to shake my hand.

"Mr. Getty, you've just gotten yourself a new contract,"

he announced with a broad smile. The remaining details were quickly agreed upon and the contract duly signed. My

"experiment" proved to be a success that had long-lasting and beneficial aftereffects.

Within the next 12 months, production and profits rose sufficiently to justify granting an additional wage increase.

A lasting bond of mutual respect was established between management and labor. To this day, any disputes are still discussed and settled in the same